

FROM IT TO AI

NARA LOKESH

Minister of HRD; IT Electronics & Communication; RTG, Andhra Pradesh

BIG CHIP OF THE OLD BLOCK

"If you accept AI, if you adapt to it, it will definitely transform lives. If you resist, you will be out of a job"

"Karnataka has Bengaluru, Tamil Nadu has Chennai, Telangana has Hyderabad, Andhra has Chandrababu Naidu. He is our competitive advantage"



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Nara Lokesh may be the inheritor of Andhra Pradesh's most illustrious political legacy, but he wears the fact lightly. The grandson of Telugu Desam Party (TDP) founder N.T. Rama Rao and the only son of Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, the 42-year-old insists he is a mere "*karyakarta* (worker)". "Being Chandrababu's son makes it 10 times harder. I am at a great disadvantage, because he sees me every day," he said at the India Today Conclave.

Asked how a Carnegie Mellon and Stanford graduate transformed into a son-of-the-soil politician, Lokesh explained, "Carnegie Mellon and Stanford are good for business. Padayatra is very important for politics." He recalled his long march—226 days over 3,000 km in 2023—which helped him appreciate the state and its nuances. "I am able to connect with issues far better now. I truly believe the transition is complete and I am able to contribute in Mr Naidu's cabinet quite successfully," he said.

Given Naidu's track record on leveraging IT, it's no surprise that Lokesh's first year as minister saw the introduction of 'WhatsApp governance', where the social media lynchpin is becoming integral to provide government services on the mobile phone. There are also plans to build a 'Data City' in Visakhapatnam .

"I believe we are at the cusp of the next IT revolution. If a state has the right ecosystem and it translates into ease of doing business, it is at the right point to accelerate itself to the top. Andhra is there now," said Lokesh. On the pioneering 'skill survey' done in his Mangalagiri constituency, Lokesh disclosed it was being tweaked for a similar statewide study, adding it could be more vital than a caste survey. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Andhra Pradesh government's Mana Mitra offers 200 citizen services now through WhatsApp. Within one month, it has got 2,000,000 users**
- **Andhra is planning a statewide skill census, to get the younger generation prepared for the future. Pilot study done in Mangalagiri constituency**
- **The state is revamping the entire education curriculum, from KG to PG, to prepare the next-generation thought leaders**